



269 CE

ZENOBIA OF PALMYRA TAKES SYRIA AND EGYPT

After the assassination of her husband Odaenathus, a strong Roman ally, Zenobia of Palmyra revolted against the Romans. Her armies seized Syria and Egypt before attacking Asia Minor. With the Roman position in the east under threat, Emperor Aurelian marched to meet her, defeating the Palmyrenes at Antioch and then besieging Palmyra, where he captured Zenobia.

◁ *Queen Zenobia Addressing her Soldiers*, Giovanni Battista Tiepolo

“You demand my surrender as though you were not aware that Cleopatra preferred to die a queen rather than remain alive.”

ZENOBIA OF PALMYRA, IN RESPONSE TO EMPEROR AURELIAN, FROM HISTORIA AUGUSTA, 4TH CENTURY CE

299 CE

▽ Sima Yan (Emperor Wu of Jin)



280 CE

THE WESTERN JIN REUNITE CHINA

Sima Yan, the grandson of a former imperial general, deposed the last Cao Wei emperor in 265 CE, declaring himself the first ruler of a new dynasty, the Western Jin. He established a new legal code, devolved power to the imperial princes, and then in 280 CE conquered the state of Eastern Wu. However, this reunification of China did not long survive Sima Yan's death a decade later.

284 CE

DIOCLETIAN DECLARED ROMAN EMPEROR

Diocletian was of humble birth but rose through the army ranks and was declared emperor after the Emperor Numerian died in mysterious circumstances during a campaign against Persia. Strong, and with a genius for organization, he saw that one man alone could not end the Military Anarchy; in 286 CE he chose another officer, Maximian, to be co-emperor, later extending the system to four emperors (the Tetrarchy).



△ The Tetrarchs, porphyry sculpture